

# U.S. Election-Security Risk Assessment

*Distilled from Tornberg Intelligence Digest 2026-02E*

DRAFT FOR REVIEW, COORDINATION, AND REVISION

## Preface for feasible action

No applied judgment or course of action should be expected to fully remediate, mitigate, or marginalize every threat vector. The implementable objective is measurable risk reduction across prevention, detection, containment, independent verification, and recovery.

## Briefing purpose

Inform senior implementers on the most pressing, actionable judgments for policy design, oversight, funding, standards, and operational assurance.

## Integrity guardrail

Preventing improper activation and preventing improper exclusion are coequal election-integrity requirements.

Source base: Intelligence Digest 2026-02E; Preliminary Intelligence Assessment 2026-02; Source Packet 2026-02B; Process Summary 2026-02A.

Priority judgments for action

BOTTOM LINE

What should drive near-term decisions

The record establishes real and warning-relevant threat vectors. It does not establish nationwide compromise of certified vote counts.

|   |                                                                                                                                                                                                     |          |
|---|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------|
| 1 | <b>Vector existence is established</b> — Documented cases, official findings, direct observation, and technical reporting show exploitable pathways.                                                | HIGH     |
| 2 | <b>Pre-entry assurance is under-standardized</b> — Eligibility, activation, deduplication, and due-process safeguards are uneven; both improper activation and improper exclusion must be measured. | MOD-HIGH |
| 3 | <b>Paper evidence is not outcome assurance</b> — Paper records are now widespread, but audit design, custody, escalation, and certification remain inconsistent.                                    | HIGH     |
| 4 | <b>Technology concentrates risk</b> — Platforms, vendors, credentials, software, and logs become high-consequence when they are the only proof.                                                     | HIGH     |
| 5 | <b>Foreign actors can exploit domestic uncertainty</b> — Data collection, influence, false narratives, and delayed corrections can produce effect without changing votes.                           | MOD-HIGH |
| 6 | <b>No reliable national ranking yet</b> — Existing evidence cannot rank vectors by national prevalence, recurrence, coordination, or outcome effect.                                                | HIGH     |

Decision use: prioritize standards and oversight against proven pathways without converting incidents, anomalies, or bounded datasets into unsupported national prevalence claims.

Key vulnerabilities and control objectives

WHERE POLICY CAN MOVE RISK

# Fix the assurance gaps that cut across vectors

The most consequential near-term opportunities are not single fraud categories. They are control weaknesses that allow multiple vectors to enter the election lifecycle, evade detection, or remain unresolved after the fact.

**Pre-entry uncertainty**  
No common outcome standard requires every legally material registration criterion to be supported before ordinary activation.  
*Objective: accurate, timely, reviewable eligibility determination.*

**Independent verification gap**  
Paper evidence is widespread, but not every material outcome is verified through statistically meaningful, independent audit.  
*Objective: reconstruct outcomes from evidence outside the originating system.*

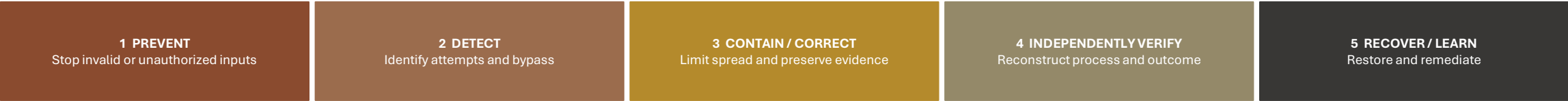
**Technology dependence**  
Platforms, vendors, credentials, logs, remote access, and fallback procedures remain uneven.  
*Objective: no critical platform is both executor and exclusive proof.*

**Fragmented detectability**  
Incident taxonomies, referrals, retention, dispositions, and control-performance measures are not consistently comparable.  
*Objective: standardize what is logged, reported, retained, investigated, and measured.*

**Data exposure**  
Voter and political data enable administration but also targeting, identity misuse, coercion, surveillance, and influence.  
*Objective: minimize disclosure, protect sensitive fields, monitor access.*

**Communication latency**  
Delays and unauthenticated corrections create space for adversaries and domestic actors to exploit uncertainty.  
*Objective: authenticate channels, pre-plan incident communications, publish verified outcomes.*

Integrated assurance model



Design test: every proposed solution should show which layer it strengthens and what metric proves the layer is working.

Threat vectors prioritized for implementation

FROM 15 VECTORS TO 6 IMPLEMENTATION FAMILIES

Act on the families that cut across the system

Use this view to align legislation, grants, standards, and oversight with exposed populations and measurable controls, not broad claims of prevalence.

| FAMILY                             | ACTIONABLE ANCHOR                                                             | CONTROL EMPHASIS                                                                   |
|------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Registration & eligibility         | 234.5M eligible records; 103M+ transactions; 10.4M duplicate transactions     | Eligibility validation; deduplication; notice/cure; dual-error metrics             |
| Identity & ballot access           | ~30% of ballots cast by mail; cure/reject data available                      | Ballot issuance controls; signature/identity review; ballot tracking               |
| Trusted access & physical custody  | 675K Election Day workers; ~15M drop-box returns in 36 states                 | Least privilege; two-person custody; sealed transfer; inventory reconciliation     |
| Technology & vendors               | 39.9% jurisdictions use e-pollbooks; >98% paper evidence                      | MFA; segmentation; hash validation; remote-access limits; manual continuity        |
| Reporting, canvass & certification | Correction latency; audit escalations; certification exceptions               | Authenticated feeds; reconciliation; escalation rules; legal/operational playbooks |
| Foreign / domestic influence       | Attributed campaigns; data exposure; correction latency; impersonation events | Authenticated comms; data minimization; prebunking; rapid response                 |

Guardrail: vector existence ≠ national prevalence or outcome effect

Immediate decision implications

MOST PRESSING ACTIONABLE ELEMENTS

Six moves for markup, oversight, and implementation

The objective is not to promise total remediation. It is to make risk reduction visible, auditable, and enforceable before the next certification window.

- 1

**Define pre-entry eligibility assurance**

Test each legally material criterion before ordinary activation (voter registration); require alternative evidence, cure, appeal, and provisional paths.
- 2

**Require control-performance metrics**

Measure improper activation, improper exclusion, secondary review, false matches, cure, appeal, reversal, and resolution time.
- 3

**Create independent outcome assurance**

Require ballot accounting, custody evidence, statistically meaningful audits, and escalation rules before certification.
- 4

**Standardize technology controls**

Minimum MFA, least privilege, logging, segmentation, software validation, vendor duties, remote-access control, and manual continuity.
- 5

**Standardize incidents and referrals**

Common taxonomy, retention, disposition tracking, evidence preservation, and cross-jurisdiction notification.
- 6

**Authenticate public communication**

Pre-validated official channels, rapid correction protocols, provenance controls, and post-incident explanation requirements.

Legislative / implementation test

Does the proposal prevent invalid inputs, preserve qualified voter access, produce independent evidence, specify measurable indicators, and define escalation before certification?

Highest-value next oversight question: Which controls are required, how is performance measured, who owns escalation, and what evidence proves the control worked?